

morning, our cash-strapped family enjoyed a bounty of gifts that included T-shirts emblazoned with the Energizer Bunny, Jolly Green Giant, or the Hershey candy bar logo; stuffed animals; radios; hats; and one Christmas, a Little Tykes dollhouse that was totally free thanks to Luvs diaper proofs of purchase. Stockings were filled with Kraft Macaroni and Cheese crayons, Flintstone and Ducktails character figurines, and foot-long pencils inscribed with the recipient's name. One year, a cigarette company offered televisions, radios, a video camera, and even a pool table, throwing avid refunders into a smoking and trading frenzy.

Back then, refund and rebate offers were plentiful, ranging from Crest-sponsored AT&T gift certificates that paid my phone bills for several months, to a free coffeemaker from Folgers and strings of M&M Christmas lights. The majority of offers were unlimited and didn't require cash register receipts, accounting for the aforementioned files that bulged with empty bags and boxes. When an offer came out, all I had to do was go to my files and pull out the proofs of purchase needed to fulfill them. I didn't stop there. I was not above filching empty candy bar wrappers from trash bins at the park or picking up the back cards of batteries from store parking lots. My children all sported Hershey shirts but ate very few of the required candy bars themselves to get them. Trips to the pool were the most rewarding, where candy was sold at the concession stand and the trash receptacles were overflowing with wrappers. On neighborhood trash day, the children and I walked up and down the alleys, where we confiscated extra Pampers points to send in for savings bonds and toys. Even the tennis